Sign in to thehill.com with Google
Continue

QUALITY OBSESSED. PRICED LESS.
Magnesium Glycinate
Shop NOW Supplements

JUST IN

The richest members of Congress in 2026
BUSINESS | 3 MINUTES AGO

Jon Stewart signs on to host 'The Daily Show' through 2028
IN THE KNOW | 15 MINUTES AGO

Schumer urges FCC to reject GOP group's request to allow unsolicited political robocalls
SENATE | 20 MINUTES AGO

Husband of soldier killed in Iranian drone strike grills Vance on 'fundamental failures'
ADMINISTRATION | 24 MINUTES AGO

Expedition fails to find Amelia Earhart's plane on remote island in Western Pacific
INTERNATIONAL | 24 MINUTES AGO

'These pilots saved our lives': Donnie Wahlberg recounts plane skidding off runway, hitting fence
TRANSPORTATION | 29 MINUTES AGO

Dimon says US economy 'booming,' but warns about 'inflationary' events
BUSINESS | 55 MINUTES AGO

Klobuchar, Demuth face off in first Minnesota governor's debate
CAMPAIGN | 1 HOUR AGO

VIEW ALL

SENATE

GOP senators press Pentagon over Ukraine's loss of Starshield data

132 BY ALEXANDER BOLTON - 10/16/26 6:00 AM ET

Listen to audio version of this article

Advertisement
Stay in the know with The Hill's newsletters Sign Up

Four Republican senators have joined their Democratic colleagues in pressing the Trump administration for information about whether Pentagon officials ordered restrictions on Ukraine's access to the satellite-based Starshield network, which Ukrainian officials said limited their ability to intercept Russian drones.

Ukraine needs access to fast Starshield data speeds to operate drones along with fixed-wing and rotary-wing aircraft, which are critical to its national defense.

ADVERTISEMENT
CLINIQUE
Simple, straightforward routines for men.
4.5 62
$43.00
prime

Ukraine's full access to Starshield-provided data was quickly restored Wednesday, prompting speculation on Capitol Hill that President Trump didn't make the call to cut off intelligence sharing with Ukraine but that the decision may have come from senior officials.

Four Republican senators — including two senior members of the Senate Intelligence Committee — signed a bipartisan letter to Platte Moring, the Pentagon's inspector general, demanding he investigate whether any Department of Defense (DOD) or other U.S. government officials "directed" or "authorized" changes to intelligence-sharing arrangements or Starlink and Starshield services affecting Ukraine.

Starshield is the military version of SpaceX's Starlink, which provides internet connectivity from low-orbit satellites.

ADVERTISEMENT

Senate Appropriations Committee Chair Susan Collins (R-Maine), a senior member of the Intelligence Committee, signed the letter, along with Sen. John Cornyn (R-Texas), another member of the Intelligence panel, and Republican Sens. Lisa Murkowski (Alaska) and Thom Tillis (N.C.).

The GOP lawmakers expressed "grave concern" over reports that Ukraine lost access to high-speed internet connectivity enabling it to operate military vehicles flying faster than 63 mph or faster than 100 mph, hampering its ability to fend off Russian strikes.

"We urgently request an Inspector General investigation into these incidents, including whether actions or decisions by the Department of Defense or its contractors contributed to these dangerous circumstances," the senators wrote.

ADVERTISEMENT
P&G Get $5 Off When You Buy 2 Items
Shop now
Terms and conditions apply.

Tillis is not running for reelection, while Cornyn lost a primary after the president backed his opponent, Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton (R). Collins is in a tough reelection race in a state Trump has lost in three consecutive presidential elections, while Murkowski is known for breaking with the president on various issues.

Sen. Jeanne Shaheen (D-N.H.), the ranking member of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, spearheaded the letter.

Democratic Sens. Dick Durbin (Ill.), Richard Blumenthal (Conn.), Chris Coons (Del.) and Jack Reed (R.I.), the ranking member of the Senate Armed Services Committee, also signed it.

ADVERTISEMENT
00:00 00:30
The New Peloton Tread Flex
Sponsored By Peloton Interactive
Sometimes thinking outside the box...mea...
Learn more

A Senate source familiar with internal discussions about how to respond to Ukraine's sudden loss of access to critical military intelligence said senators in both parties have questions about whether Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth or other senior defense officials — such as Elbridge Colby, the undersecretary of defense for policy — were involved in the decision.

Lawmakers blamed Hegseth and Colby, the No. 3-ranking Pentagon official, last year for repeatedly holding up shipments of missiles and ammunition to Ukraine.

Tillis, a leading advocate of U.S. military support for Ukraine, first called on the Pentagon's inspector general Wednesday evening to investigate the matter.

ADVERTISEMENT
Upgrade your Christmas decor
Shop now
amazon

He expressed skepticism that Hegseth would answer senators' questions about the Starshield outage if called to testify on Capitol Hill.

"The latest reporting suggests this strategic snafu may have occurred more locally within DOD Starshield systems, not with Starlink or SpaceX," Tillis wrote on social media Wednesday.

"I'm not holding my breath for Defense Secretary Hegseth to offer transparency, so we'll be asking the DOD Inspector General to initiate an investigation and report back to Congress and the American People," he said.

ADVERTISEMENT
BioGaia
Relieves Colic, Gas & Spit Ups*
4.7 1,479
$17.99 $20.99
Subscribe & Save 14%
prime

"At best, this was an unacceptable error or lapse," Tillis fumed, saying that at worst it was a conscious "decision to clear the field for a Russian attack."

John Ullyot, a former spokesperson for the Senate Armed Services Committee and former deputy assistant to Trump, said senators have good reason to question senior Pentagon officials for answers about the Starshield outage.

"Hegseth reportedly cut off weapons to Ukraine without the President's sign-off three times in his first six months on the job, so it's not surprising senators want to know if he was involved here as well," Ullyot said.

ADVERTISEMENT
easy spirit
THE POWER PUMP
SHOP NOW

"Either way, Republicans shouldn't have to be dealing with these distractions from DoD less than three weeks before the midterms," he added.

Senators who support continued U.S. military aid to Ukraine believe Hegseth's office ordered a temporary halt to military aid flights to Ukraine in early February 2025 without notifying the White House.

The halt to air traffic reportedly impacted nearly a dozen shipments of artillery shells and weapons from Dover Air Force Base and a base in the United Arab Emirates.

ADVERTISEMENT
A FILM BY CHRISTOPHER NOLAN
THE ODYSSEY
WATCH AT HOME
NOVEMBER 17

Hegseth was accused of unilaterally delaying military aid to Ukraine again in May and July of last year.

The Pentagon said in July 2025 that it delayed weapons shipments to Ukraine because of a concern over low stockpiles, but lawmakers at the time rejected that rationale.

Rep. Adam Smith (Wash.), the top Democrat on the House Armed Services Committee, at the time argued that the Pentagon's stockpile of weapons and ammunition wasn't any lower than it had been in the previous 3 1/2 years of the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

Republican national security insiders think that if senior DOD officials ordered a limitation on Ukraine's access to Starshield and other critical intelligence sharing, they may have acted without Trump's explicit knowledge or approval.

Suspicion on Capitol Hill over whether Hegseth, Colby or other senior Pentagon officials played a role in limiting Ukraine's access to Starshield gained momentum Wednesday after Elon Musk, the founder and CEO of SpaceX, which owns and operates Starlink, pointed the finger at the Pentagon.

Musk wrote on X, the social media platform which he also owns, that "Starshield systems are owned and controlled by the U.S. government" and that "any limits on speed or usage are decided by the U.S. military and ultimately" the president of the United States.

Ukraine's access to Starshield was quickly restored after the disruptions to high-speed data attracted media scrutiny and criticism from Republicans and Democrats on Capitol Hill.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky on Wednesday called the loss of access to Starshield a "big mistake."

"People will die, of course, if attacks will continue and if Starlink will not work … it's not helpful," he warned.

ADD AS PREFERRED SOURCE ON GOOGLE

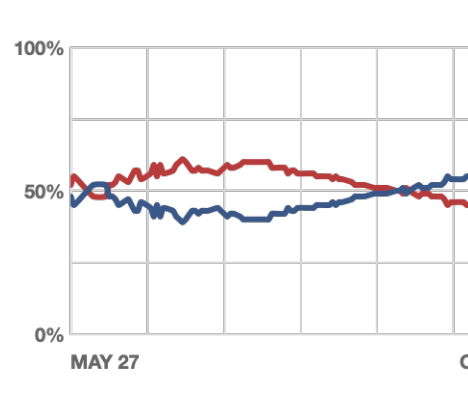
TAGS ADAM SMITH CHRIS COONS DICK DURBIN DONALD TRUMP ELON MUSK JACK REED JEANNE SHAHEEN JOHN CORNYN KEN PAXTON LISA MURKOWSKI PETE HEGSETH RICHARD BLUMENTHAL SUSAN COLLINS THOM TILLIS VOLODYMYR ZELENSKY

Copyright 2026 Nexstar Media Inc. All rights reserved. This material may not be published, broadcast, rewritten, or redistributed.

00:00 00:42
Try Newt AI
Sponsored By Becker Accounting
Becker students can now get immediate answers and instant insights with Newt™ AI! Built with Becker's curriculum, you'll get the accurate, reliable information you…
Learn more

Senate Forecast

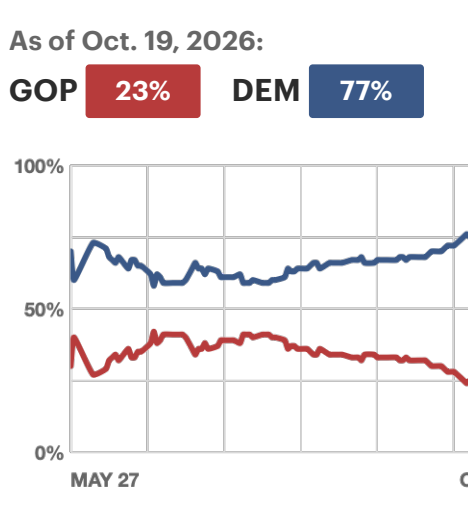
As of Oct. 19, 2026:
GOP 44% DEM 56%



View Full Forecast
DDHQ | THE HILL

House Forecast

As of Oct. 19, 2026:
GOP 23% DEM 77%



View Full Forecast
DDHQ | THE HILL

NATROL
Subscribe & Save for a Great Night's Sleep!
$13.30
prime
*These statements have not been evaluated by the FDA.

FOR HILL INSIDERS

GOP, Trump, Hegseth tangle on Russia amid rising midterm pressures
EDITOR'S CALL 10/19/26

Before, during, after: Outside groups race to counter any election interference by Trump
CAMPAIGN 10/19/26

Libertarians may tip the balance in key Senate races. Here's why.
CAMPAIGN 10/19/26

Bulldozed trees spike DC tensions: Inside Trump's takeover of East Potomac Park
KEEPING SCORE 10/19/26

Read More

Most Popular

1 Hegseth's future as Pentagon chief at center of lame-duck…
2 Kimberly Guilfoyle's resignation doesn't end an investigation — it…
3 Judge refuses DOJ's demand to step aside from golf course…
4 Johnson says he warned White House of 'unintended…
5 Judge presses federal government on East Potomac takeover…
6 Trump approval hits record low in new survey

Load more

What Do You Think?

Do you think the Pentagon's handling of Ukraine's loss of Starshield data warrants an investigation?

○ Yes, I think so
○ Maybe, I'm not sure
○ No, I don't think so
○ Other / No opinion

* By clicking "NEXT" I submit my answers and consent to the use of cookies for research and advertising purposes; I have read and agree to the CivicScience Privacy Policy and Terms of Service

NEXT *

People were interested in these podcasts

SPONSORED CONTENT
Privacy Policy
Brain Health Documentary
MDs Say Mental Decline Begins When Seniors Can't Pronounce… Celestium Digital | Sponsored
MDs Say Cognitive Decline Begins When Seniors Often Say These 3… Wellness and Safe 101 | Sponsored
Man Who Predicted the Election Reveals His New Midterm Forecast Daily Stock Traders | Sponsored
At 66, I Stopped Wearing Bras. Here's What I Wear Instead Comfort Living Today | Sponsored
Neuropathy Is Not From Damaged Nerves In Your Feet. Meet The Real Enemy (Stop Doing This) Smoothspine | Sponsored
Man Who Predicted Election Victory Issues Shocking New… Paradigm Press | Sponsored
MDs Say Cognitive Decline Begins When Seniors Often Say These 3… Celestium Digital | Sponsored
Restaurants In Lake View With Good Senior Discounts
Seniors at NY Should Claim These Benefits
Comparisons.org | Sponsored
Most people know how to stop mice at fall, but did you know this… mice | Sponsored
Best Christmas Gift: Here Are 27+ Of The Coolest Gifts For 2026 Gift List | Sponsored
STENOSIS
Spinal Stenosis Isn't An Age Problem — The Real Cause May Surprise You(Stop Doing This) Smoothspine | Sponsored
MDs Say Cognitive Decline Begins When Seniors Often Say These 3… The Vitality Wisdom Project | Sponsored
I Started Looking for Christmas Gifts. Then I Found These. OKJU | Sponsored
Best Christmas Gift: Here Are 27+ of The Coolest Gifts for 2026 Top Trending Gadgets Daily | Sponsored
BEFORE AFTER
Why Your Rotator Cuff Won't Heal (What Most Doctors Miss) Shoulder Relief News | Sponsored
Chronic tinnitus has been associated with a common practice. EarCare | News | Sponsored
At 69, I Stopped Wearing Bras. Here's What I Wear Instead Comfort Living Today | Sponsored
A Billionaire's Reading List: 5 Books Mark Cuban Says Everyon… Blinkist Magazine | Sponsored

CONTENT CONTINUES BELOW SURVEY

What Do You Think?

Loading survey...

More Senate News SEE ALL

BUSINESS
The richest members of Congress in 2026
BY JOSIE FISCHELS
4 minutes ago

SENATE
Schumer urges FCC to reject GOP group's request to allow unsolicited political robocalls
BY FINYA SWAI
20 minutes ago

SENATE
Warren warns against Sysco-Restaurant Depot merger
BY MAX REGO
4 hours ago

SENATE
Wicker calls on Trump, Zelensky to broker deal to stop strikes on Russian energy infrastructure
BY ALEXANDER BOLTON
6 hours ago

Video/Hill.TV SEE ALL HILL.TV SEE ALL VIDEO

THE HILL TV
Rising: October 19, 2026
BY THEHILL.COM
10/19/26 10:57 AM ET

THE HILL TV
Rising: October 16, 2026
BY THEHILL.COM
3 days ago

THE HILL TV
Rising: October 15, 2026
BY THEHILL.COM
4 days ago

Top Stories SEE ALL

COURT BATTLES
Judge presses federal government on East Potomac takeover despite Trump attacks
BY SOPHIE BRAMS AND DOMINICK MASTRANGELO
1 hour ago

00:00 01:06
New Peloton Tread Revealed
Sponsored By Peloton Interactive
#ad Peloton revealed their new treadmill, the Peloton Tread Vis
Learn more

DON'T MISS A BRIEF. SIGN UP FOR OUR DAILY EMAIL.

Your Email

→

News

- SENATE
- HOUSE
- CAMPAIGN
- 2026 MIDTERM ELECTIONS
- REGULATION
- MEDIA
- IN THE KNOW
- MORE

Policy

- DEFENSE
- ENERGY & ENVIRONMENT
- HEALTHCARE
- TECHNOLOGY
- INTERNATIONAL
- TRANSPORTATION
- CYBERSECURITY
- NATIONAL SECURITY
- MORE

Video

- NEWS VIDEO CLIPS
- POLITICAL NEWS CLIPS
- THE HILL ON YOUTUBE
- THE HILL - RISING
- WHOLE HOG POLITICS
- MORE

Opinion

- CONTRIBUTORS TO THE HILL
- COLUMNISTS
- CONGRESS BLOG
- MORE

Resources

- SITEMAP
- THE HILL APPS
- PEOPLE
- RSS
- PRINT EDITION

Other Areas

- MEDIA

Contributors

- SUBMIT OPINION CONTENT

About Us

- WORK FOR THE HILL
- INTERNSHIPS
- CONTACT SUPPORT

Follow Us On

Get the App

What is Starshield? SpaceX&#039;s military sa…

PRIVACY POLICY 09/30/2025 NOTICE AT COLLECTION TERMS & CONDITIONS CONTACT

ADVERTISE WITH THE HILL NEWSNATION BESTREVIEWS ADVERTISE WITH NEXSTAR

JOURNALISTIC INTEGRITY YOUR PRIVACY CHOICES

THE HILL 400 N CAPITOL STREET NW, SUITE 650 WASHINGTON DC 20002

29 Discounts Seniors Only Get if They Ask

WalletJump